

THE SOCIALIZATION OF LABOR AND THE ORGANIC COMPOSITION OF CAPITAL: A STUDY IN PRODUCTIVE CONTRADICTIONS

I. THE CENTRAL CONTRADICTION: SOCIAL POWER IN ALIENATED FORM

At the core of the relation between the socialization of labor and the organic composition of capital lies a contradiction that structures the entire analysis: the progressive development of labor's social productive powers is simultaneously the process by which those powers are stripped from the producers and confront them as attributes of capital. The organic composition of capital – the ratio of constant to variable capital insofar as it reflects the technical composition of the production process – is the quantitative registration of this inversion. It measures not merely a proportion between inputs, but the degree to which living, cooperative human labor has been displaced by the objectified products of past labor, organized under the command of capital.

Marx states the inversion directly: "not only do these things – these products of labour, both as use values and as exchange values – stand on their hind legs vis-à-vis the worker and confront him as 'capital' – but also the social forms of labour appear as forms of the development of capital, and therefore the productive powers of social labour, thus developed, appear as productive powers of capital" (Marx, 1864). In the same proportion as social productive power develops, "the pile of wealth confronting the worker grows, as wealth ruling over him, as capital, and the world of wealth expands vis-à-vis the worker as an alien and dominating world. At the opposite pole, and in the same proportion, the worker's subjective poverty, neediness and dependency develop" (Marx, 1864).

This is neither a logical error to be corrected nor a moral complaint. It is the objective structure of capitalist production: the organic composition of capital is the value-form through which the socialization of labor presents itself within capitalist relations. The two concepts stand in an internal relation – neither can be fully determined without the other. The socialization of labor is the real content of which the rising organic composition is the value-form. The organic composition registers the degree to which production depends on cooperative, scientifically organized labor rather than individual skill; yet it registers this dependency in the inverted form of capital's growing domination over living labor. Every advance in cooperation, in the division of labor, in the application of machinery and science, appears as an increase in constant capital's command over the diminishing proportion of variable capital.

The contradiction is productive: it generates the entire chain of consequences – the tendential fall in the rate of profit, concentration and centralization of capital, transitional forms such as joint-stock companies and credit, and ultimately the material conditions for a mode of production in which the social character of labor need no longer assume the alienated form of capital. Working through this contradiction at each level of determination reveals not a flaw in the analysis but the self-undermining logic of capitalist accumulation itself.

II. THE FIRST TENSION: FORMAL SUBSUMPTION AND THE GENESIS OF SOCIALIZATION

THE OPPOSING POLES

The first productive tension concerns how the socialization of labor begins. Capital initially takes over the labor process as it finds it – handicraft, small-scale production – without transforming its technical character. Marx insists on this: "As yet there is no difference in the mode of production itself. The labour process continues exactly as it did before – from the technological point of view – only as a labour process now subordinated to capital" (Marx, 1864). Under formal subsumption, capital commands the process but does not reshape it. There is, strictly speaking, no change in the organic composition that arises from a transformation of the mode of production; the technical composition remains as it was inherited from pre-capitalist forms.

Yet formal subsumption is not merely a preparatory stage to be left behind. It is the logical and historical precondition for real subsumption: capital must first establish dominance over the labor process before it can revolutionize that process. Simple cooperation – the gathering of many workers under one roof performing the same or similar operations – already creates productive powers that exceed the sum of individual efforts. These are, as Marx writes, "natural forces provided free of charge by social labour in the particular forms it takes on under the rule of capital" (Marx, 1863). Cooperation is "the basic form" on which all more developed forms rest (Engels, 1868).

WHAT THE TENSION PRODUCES

The tension between formal subsumption (capital commands but does not transform the labor process) and real subsumption (capital reshapes the labor process in its own image) is resolved dynamically: the social productive forces generated under formal subsumption create the material basis and the competitive pressure for the transition to real subsumption. But the resolution is never complete. Formal subsumption persists alongside real subsumption wherever capital encounters labor processes it has not yet technically revolutionized – a point of considerable significance for peripheral economies where pre-capitalist, formally subsumed, and fully capitalist relations coexist within a single social formation.

This tension thus drives the analysis forward: from the question of how labor becomes social under capital to the question of the forms through which this socialization progressively develops and transforms the technical composition.

III. THE SECOND TENSION: PROGRESSIVE SOCIALIZATION AND THE TECHNICAL COMPOSITION

THE THREE STAGES AS A SPIRAL OF DISPLACEMENT

The socialization of labor develops through three successive forms – simple cooperation, manufacturing division of labor, and machinery with large-scale industry – each of which deepens the displacement of living labor by objectified labor, and thereby transforms the technical composition of capital.

In **cooperation**, the collective labor force acquires powers the isolated worker cannot develop, but the individual labor process remains technically unchanged. The social productive power "appears as a productive power of capital, not of labour. And this transposition takes place within capitalist production in respect of all the productive powers of social labour" (Marx, 1863).

In **manufacture**, the labor process is analytically decomposed into partial operations. The worker "has altogether ceased to be the producer of a commodity. He is only the producer of a one-sided operation, which in general produces something solely in connection with the whole of the mechanism that forms the workshop" (Marx, 1863). Here, as Engels summarized, "the intellectual faculties of labour disappear as far as the many are concerned, to expand in scope for the one" (Engels, 1868). The worker becomes "a living constituent of the workshop" and "an accessory to capital through the manner of his work" (Marx, 1863). Yet manufacture, while revolutionizing the subjective side of the labor process, still rests on the worker's manual skill.

Machinery resolves this limitation by transferring the tool from the worker to a mechanism. The Grundrisse identifies this as the moment when capital finds its "adequate" form: "In the machine, and to an even greater degree in machine[ry] as an automatic system, the means of labour is transformed, with respect to its use value, i.e. to its material character, into a form adequate to fixed capital and to capital in general" (Marx, 1858). The worker becomes "a mere living accessory of this machinery, as the means of its action" (Marx, 1858). It is "only in machinery" that "the replacement of workers by a part of constant capital... exists; in general, only here does the rendering of the workers superfluous emerge as an explicit and conscious tendency and a tendency acting on a large scale" (Marx, 1864).

THE CONTRADICTION INTERNAL TO THE SEQUENCE

Each stage advances the socialization of labor – makes the labor process more collective, more interdependent, more dependent on the social organization of production rather than individual capacity. Yet each stage simultaneously deepens the worker's subordination to capital, making the social character of labor appear ever more completely as a power of the means of production that confronts the worker as alien property. Manufacture "produced the machinery, by means of which modern industry abolished the handicraft and manufacturing systems" (Marx, 1867) – but it did so by first reducing the worker to a detail function, creating the very conditions for mechanical replacement.

This is not an inconsistency but a dialectical contradiction internal to the concept: the progressive socialization of labor is, within capitalist relations, simultaneously the progressive dispossession of the laborer. The 1861–63 manuscript captures both sides: "On the one hand the capitalist mode of production... creates a change in the shape of material production. On the other hand this change in the material shape forms the basis for the development of the capital-relation, whose adequate shape therefore only corresponds to a particular level of development of the material forces of production" (Marx, 1864).

IV. THE THIRD TENSION: TECHNICAL COMPOSITION AND VALUE COMPOSITION

THE MEDIATING PROBLEM

The transition from the technical composition (the physical ratio of means of production to living labor) to the organic composition (this ratio expressed in value terms) introduces a

tension that Marx acknowledges but does not fully resolve. The same productivity increase that multiplies the mass of means of production relative to living labor also cheapens each unit of those means of production. As Capital I states: "The reason is simply that, with the increasing productivity of labour, not only does the mass of the means of production consumed by it increase, but their value compared with their mass diminishes. Their value therefore rises absolutely, but not in proportion to their mass" (Marx, 1867).

Marx's treatment in the Theories of Surplus Value introduces a systematic distinction. Case A: "A change in the mode of production brings about a change in the proportion between the amounts of constant and variable capital employed" (Marx, 1863) – this is an organic change in the strict sense, arising from the socialization of labor. Case B: "The mode of production remains the same. There is a change in the ratio of constant to variable capital... caused by a change in the value of the commodities which enter into constant or variable capital" (Marx, 1863) – this is a value change that mimics an organic change without reflecting any transformation in the labor process.

Only Case A properly connects the socialization of labor to the organic composition. The Cherbuliez discussion makes the complication explicit: "If 1 worker can spin as much cotton as 100 [workers spun previously], then the [supply of] raw material must be increased a hundredfold... But if simultaneously one worker produces as much cotton as 100 workers did previously... then the ratio of value remains the same" (Marx, 1863). Marx concludes that "the cheapening of raw materials, and of *matières instrumentales*, etc., checks but does not cancel the growing value of this part of capital" (Marx, 1863).

STATUS OF THE TENSION

This tension is genuinely productive. Whether the rising technical composition necessarily entails a rising organic composition in value terms depends on an empirical-historical determination: do the cheapening effects of rising productivity in the means-of-production sectors keep pace with the expanding mass of means of production employed? Marx treats the rising organic composition as "confirmed at every step" by comparative analysis (Marx, 1867) and as derivable "from the general nature of capital" (Marx, 1863), while simultaneously acknowledging that the value composition rises "less than the technical composition." The corpus does not fully adjudicate whether this is a logical necessity of capitalist accumulation or a very strong historical tendency; it presents the proposition in both registers simultaneously. This ambiguity is not a deficiency but reflects the character of the object: the organic composition is precisely the category in which the logical and historical dimensions of capital's development converge.

V. THE FOURTH TENSION: THE RATE OF PROFIT AS SELF-CONTRADICTORY EXPRESSION

TWO MOVEMENTS IN OPPOSITE DIRECTIONS

The rising organic composition generates what Marx calls "the most important law of political economy": the tendential fall in the general rate of profit (Marx, 1863). The mechanism is structurally straightforward: since surplus value is produced only by living labor (variable capital), but is measured against total capital advanced ($c + v$), a rising proportion of constant capital necessarily depresses the ratio $s/(c + v)$ – unless the rate of surplus value (s/v) rises fast enough to compensate.

Here the contradiction sharpens. The same process that raises the organic composition also raises the rate of surplus value – more productive labor creates more surplus value per

worker. Capital III states explicitly: "The two movements not only go hand in hand, but mutually influence one another and are phenomena in which the same law expresses itself. Yet they affect the rate of profit in opposite ways" (Marx, 1894). The 1861–63 Manuscript makes the same point: the rising rate of surplus value and the falling proportion of workers relative to capital "work in opposite directions, in so far as the rate of profit comes into consideration" (Marx, 1863).

THE ABSOLUTE LIMIT

Marx provides a decisive argument for why the rate of surplus value cannot ultimately compensate: "One man may produce as much use value as 90. Never more than an average of 12 hours a day in value" (Marx, 1863). The working day sets an absolute ceiling on the value a single worker can produce, however productive that labor becomes. Meanwhile, there is "absolutely no rational reason why the rise of productive power should observe exactly the same numerical ratio" as the decline in variable capital relative to total capital (Marx, 1863). The Grundrisse makes the point architecturally: "The broader the existence already attained by capital, the smaller is the ratio of the value newly produced to that preposited" (Marx, 1858).

Yet this remains a tendency, not an absolute law. The counteracting tendencies – cheapening of constant capital elements, increasing intensity of exploitation, foreign trade, expansion into new sectors – mean that the fall is always mediated by historical and contingent factors (Marx, 1894). The corpus leaves genuinely open whether the rate of profit's decline precipitates crises primarily through overaccumulation of capital or through the disproportion between production and effective demand. Marx identifies multiple crisis paths – overproduction of capital, overproduction of commodities, the contradiction between conditions of production and conditions of realization of surplus value (Marx, 1894) – without definitively subordinating one to the others.

VI. THE FIFTH TENSION: THE CATEGORICAL FRAMEWORK ITSELF

ORGANIC COMPOSITION VS. SMITHIAN CATEGORIES

An often-overlooked dimension of the analysis concerns the categorical conditions for even perceiving the relation between the socialization of labor and the organic composition. The distinction between constant and variable capital – the foundation of the organic composition concept – differs fundamentally from the Smithian distinction between fixed and circulating capital. Marx argues in Capital II that the common designation "circulating capital," by grouping raw materials with wages, "abolishes this essential difference" and obscures "the entire secret of capitalist production" (Marx, 1885). The constant/variable distinction asks who creates new value (only living labor does); the fixed/circulating distinction asks how value is transferred to the product (piecemeal vs. wholly).

This matters because the Smithian framework systematically cannot register the transformation that the socialization of labor effects. As Capital II, Chapter XI states: "It is wholly immaterial for the organic composition of capital whether a specified quantity of value of constant capital consists of many instruments of labour and little material of labour or of much material of labour and few instruments of labour, while everything depends on the ratio of the capital laid out in means of production to that laid out in labour power" (Marx, 1885). The Smithian categories place raw materials alongside wages as "circulating capital," thereby rendering invisible the fundamental shift in the proportion of dead to living labor that the socialization of labor produces. "The absolutely decisive distinction between the variable and constant capital is thereby

blotted out, hence the whole secret of the production of surplus value and of capitalist production" (Marx, 1885).

This is not merely a terminological preference. The relation between socialization of labor and organic composition is invisible within the received categories of political economy. It can only be apprehended through the constant/variable distinction, which itself presupposes the distinction between labor and labor-power – the concept that separates Marx's value theory from its classical predecessors.

VII. THE SPIRAL COMPLETED: SOCIAL PRODUCTION AGAINST PRIVATE APPROPRIATION

CONCENTRATION, CENTRALIZATION, AND CAPITAL'S SELF-DISSOLUTION

The tendential fall in the rate of profit, driven by the rising organic composition, generates a further set of consequences that return the analysis to the central contradiction at a higher level. The falling rate of profit raises the minimum capital required for profitable operation. Small capitals are ruined; larger capitals absorb them. "The battle of competition is fought by cheapening of commodities. The cheapness of commodities depends, *ceteris paribus*, on the productiveness of labour, and this again on the scale of production. Therefore, the larger capitals beat the smaller" (Marx, 1867). The credit system functions as "the specific machine for the centralisation of capitals" (Marx, 1867). Capital III notes a self-reinforcing spiral: "At a certain high point this increasing concentration in its turn causes a new fall in the rate of profit" (Marx, 1894).

The result is that the socialization of labor, which began as a technical process within the workshop, is driven outward to encompass the entire social metabolism. Engels captured the widening arc: "The means of production, and production itself, had become in essence socialised. But they were subjected to a form of appropriation which presupposes the private production of individuals... This contradiction, which gives to the new mode of production its capitalistic character, contains the germ of the whole of the social antagonisms of to-day" (Engels, 1880).

TRANSITIONAL FORMS

Capital is driven to create institutional forms that partially acknowledge the social character of the productive forces while remaining within the framework of private property. Joint-stock companies represent "the abolition of capital as private property within the framework of the capitalist mode of production itself" (Marx, 1894). Engels identifies this as "a self-dissolving contradiction, which *prima facie* represents a mere phase of transition to a new form of production" (Marx, 1894). These are not resolutions of the fundamental contradiction but expressions of it – forms in which capital confesses the inadequacy of private property relations to contain the productive forces it has itself socialized.

THE CULMINATION

The 1861–63 Manuscript states the culmination directly: "The contradiction between the general social power which capital is formed into, and the private power of the individual capitalist over these social conditions of production becomes ever more glaring, and implies the dissolution of this relation, since it implies at the same time the development of the material conditions of production into general, therefore communal social conditions of production" (Marx, 1863). Capital III locates the barrier: "The real barrier of

capitalist production is capital itself. It is that capital and its self-expansion appear as the starting and the closing point, the motive and the purpose of production; that production is only production for capital and not vice versa" (Marx, 1894).

Capital I, Chapter XXXII, provides the most compressed formulation of the entire spiral: "The monopoly of capital becomes a fetter upon the mode of production, which has sprung up and flourished along with, and under it. Centralisation of the means of production and socialisation of labour at last reach a point where they become incompatible with their capitalist integument. Thus integument is burst asunder. The knell of capitalist private property sounds. The expropriators are expropriated" (Marx, 1867).

VIII. THE STATUS OF THE CONTRADICTIONS

CONTRADICTIONS RESOLVED WITHIN THE CORPUS

The **transposition thesis** – that social productive powers of labor appear as productive powers of capital – is resolved within the theory as an objective feature of capitalist production, not an ideological error or perceptual illusion. The rising organic composition is its quantitative measure. "The transposition of the social productive powers of labour into material attributes of capital is so strongly rooted in people's minds that the advantages of machinery, of the application of science, inventions, etc., in this alienated form are conceived of as the necessary form" (Marx, 1864).

The **categorical distinction** between organic composition and Smithian fixed/circulating capital is definitively resolved: these are different analytical frameworks answering different questions. Any analysis that conflates them cannot apprehend the mechanism connecting the socialization of labor to the organic composition.

The **qualification** that value composition rises less than technical composition is resolved as internal to the theory: it explains why the fall in the rate of profit is a tendency subject to counteracting influences, not an arithmetic inevitability.

CONTRADICTIONS LEFT GENUINELY OPEN

The **precise mechanism** by which technical composition translates into value composition remains a site of productive ambiguity. Whether the cheapening of constant capital elements can, in principle, fully offset the growth of their mass is an empirical-historical question that the corpus does not resolve deductively. Marx argues that cheapening "checks but does not cancel" the tendency, but the theoretical grounds for this claim rest partly on historical observation rather than logical demonstration alone.

The **crisis mechanism** through which the falling rate of profit manifests remains genuinely plural. The corpus identifies overaccumulation, overproduction, and disproportionality as distinct but interconnected paths; it does not subordinate them to a single primary cause.

The **status of the law of the falling rate of profit** itself – whether it is a logical necessity derivable from the concept of capital or a historically dominant tendency – straddles both registers. Marx presents it as derivable "from the general nature of capital" (Marx, 1863) and simultaneously calls it "the most important law of modern political economy" (Marx, 1858), suggesting both logical and empirical authority. The tension between these registers is not resolved but is itself constitutive of the category of tendency (Tendenz) in Marx's method.

It must also be noted that Capital Volumes II and III were compiled by Engels from disorderly manuscripts, and editorial decisions – particularly in the presentation of the

falling rate of profit and its counteracting tendencies – may interpolate a degree of systematic order not fully present in the original drafts.

CONTRADICTIONS TAKEN UP BY LATER TRADITIONS IN DIVERGENT WAYS

The tension between the logical and historical registers of the rising organic composition has been taken up by fundamentally opposed traditions. One line of interpretation treats the rising organic composition and the falling rate of profit as iron laws, generating mechanical breakdown theories. Another treats them as tendencies perpetually offset by counteracting forces, rendering the law empirically indeterminate. A third – rooted in dependency theory and the analysis of peripheral capitalism – reads the rising organic composition at the center as structurally linked to the suppression of organic composition at the periphery, where superexploitation (payment of labor-power below its value), formal subsumption persisting alongside real subsumption, and the political construction of an international division of labor maintain low-composition production as a functional complement to metropolitan capital. On this reading, the contradiction between social production and private appropriation operates not only within national capitals but across the world system, where combined and uneven development ensures that the socialization of labor and the organic composition do not rise uniformly but through a structured hierarchy of relations.

The corpus itself opens this trajectory. The process of "so-called primitive accumulation" that Marx treats in Capital I as the historical genesis of the capital relation is not a completed episode but a permanent structural feature where capital continually encounters, subordinates, and transforms non-capitalist relations. The organic composition of capital, as the value-registration of labor's socialization, is thus never a merely national measure: it indexes a global process in which the most advanced socialization of labor in some regions depends on the maintenance of less socialized – formally subsumed, hybrid, or forcibly underdeveloped – labor processes elsewhere.

What remains, across all these divergent appropriations, is the central insight: the organic composition of capital is not a neutral technical ratio but the form in which the fundamental contradiction of capitalist production – between the social character of labor and the private form of appropriation – is quantitatively registered, tendentially intensified, and historically driven toward its own resolution.

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